



The Lines and Dots test

effect that generally surrounds white and light-coloured pixels in a scene). This test tries to minimise this. The relative sharpness of the grey and white patterns should be studied. Look for the size of the dots inside the "O"s, and the gaps between the lines. You can fiddle with the contrast setting to achieve something of a compromise, since the Bloom effect cannot be completely done away with; causing it to disappear completely will result in the display becoming too dark.

9. Now you're presented with a screen consisting of a set of black strips separated by white lines, and white strips separated by black lines. The Contrast control has to be adjusted here. Increasing it will result in the white strips gradually encroaching on the black lines. This loss in sharpness occurs because as the beam current is increased, the width also increases. You will have to settle for a look that feels



Fine-tuning the contrast levels

right to you, because anomalies are present at all contrast levels; it is just what is noticeable and what's not.

10. Colour contrast is what we check in this test. Black and coloured text is placed on dark-grey, grey and white backgrounds. Basically, the black text should have sharp edges on all backgrounds and appear uniformly black. The coloured text should not have any bright or dark ridges around it.

Your display is now calibrated. Note that calibration doesn't follow a formula; it's simply what looks best to you. Then there's colour temperature to be considered; each colour temperature relates to the type of lighting where the monitor is being used, but on average, 6500 K is arguably the ideal colour temperature to select. A higher colour temperature (measured in Kelvin or K) causes a bluish tinge, while a lower value causes a reddish tinge. Though we've said 6500 is ideal, you'll need to experiment.

Your graphics card settings also affect what you view. Ideally, set your graphics card to its default settings, and turn off special effects such as dynamic colour and high-contrast settings. But a few points are in order:

1. Experiment with the settings. If you actually want an artificially bright screen, go ahead!
2. Some monitors are too dark even after proper calibration, in which case you might want to pump up the brightness and/or contrast on your graphics card through the software.
3. Some movies may be too dark for you, in which case you'll need to use the software.
4. If you want a special look—say an overly red or a cool blue look—you can also tweak the gamma settings of your graphics card. ■

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### Advantages of a CRT Monitor

CRT technology has been around for a long while now. With the coming of LCDs, our good old bulky boys have been referred to as "eye strainers," and despite the amount of radiation they emit, not to mention their inherently higher power-consuming capabilities (not a good thing), they are still around! There are three distinct reasons for this.

First, an LCD simply cannot match the sheer image quality, contrast and sharpness that a CRT can provide. Watching a movie on a CRT gives you a much richer viewing experience than an LCD can, and we're talking about a normal CRT as compared to even a relatively high-end LCD. This is largely due to the fact that CRT technology has gone through numerous refinements over the years, whereas LCDs are still sort of a "work in progress," with refinements still being made as regards features, production process, etc.

A serious shortcoming with all LCDs is noticeable by any gamer—their response time. Unlike a CRT, which has a virtually negligible response time—the time gap between the on and off of an individual pixel—LCDs have much larger response times, resulting in the ghosting effect

one sees when gaming (or even watching movies) on them.

Flat panels also have much lower contrast ratios (the ratio or difference between the lightest and darkest areas of a screen) than CRTs. For example, a man sitting near a campfire at night: a CRT will easily capture the finer nuances, while an LCD will have problems, especially with depicting the areas around the campfire edges, where light meet darkness.

Besides these technical flaws that LCDs haven't ironed out as yet, there remains the price issue. LCDs cost nearly three times more than a CRT of the same size. While a 19-inch CRT may cost you around Rs 12,000, a decent LCD of the same size would set you back by around Rs 25,000 if not more! This is because while manufacturing LCDs, there is a high product discard rate—close to 40 per cent (this figure is constantly on the decline) of all LCDs made fail the testing standards, and the products that are cleared for sale have to bear the production costs of the rejected pieces.

In short—if you want movies and games, make some room on that table—a good ol' CRT is still the way to go!

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